

1. The Person

My mom. She is a first-generation immigrant and primarily speaks Korean. I chose her because I see her struggle with technology and language barriers almost daily, especially in situations that feel important or urgent. I am often the person she relies on to help her interpret and respond, which gives me direct access to the problem and a clear understanding of where things break down.

2. The Problem (Working Theory — one sentence, a guess)

My mom receives important emails (such as permits, bills, or official notices) that she can partially translate, but she struggles to understand what actions she needs to take, so she depends on me to interpret and guide her.

3. The Listening Plan

I will talk to her within the next few days during a normal moment when she is checking or dealing with emails. I will ask for her permission to observe and take notes before starting, and I will clearly explain that this is for a class project. I will ask her to walk me through a recent or current email she didn't understand, and I will focus on listening rather than suggesting solutions. If she is comfortable, I may take photos or screenshots of the email for documentation.

4. What Helped Looks Like

(leave blank)

5. The Approach (Working Theory, loose sketch, a guess)

A tool that sits alongside or on top of email and helps break down messages into clear, simple steps. Instead of just translating the text, it would highlight what is important, explain what the email is asking, and guide her through what to do next in a more structured and understandable way.

6. Your Position Going In

What matters is that she feels confident and independent when handling important information, not overwhelmed or dependent on me. I want to prioritize clarity, trust, and simplicity over adding more features. I am worried about oversimplifying the problem into just "translation" and missing the deeper issue of understanding and decision-making. I also want to make sure I don't assume I already know her experience and instead actually listen.

7. What This Project Is Not (Scope Fences)

- This is not a generic translation app.
- This is not a full email client replacement.
- This is not designed for all users, it is specifically for my mom's needs.
- This is not focused on visual polish or complexity over clarity.
- This is not trying to solve every type of communication, only important and action-based emails.

